Even though you couldn’t always be certain how the judges you appointed would act once they put on black robes, I intended to do my best to choose the most responsible and politically neutral jurists I could find.

When I was governor, we’d instituted a system for selecting California judges that I was very proud of—independently canvassing lawyers, judges, and key citizens in a community to select the best-qualified candidate for a judicial opening. In Washington, we couldn’t do it that way, because the federal judiciary was so large and covered the whole country. But I asked Bill Smith and Ed Meese to develop within the Justice Department a system for screening potential judges, taking into account input from their peers and applying the same kind of standards we’d used in California. I said I didn’t want politics to play any part in the selection, I wanted the *best* man or woman for the job. The only litmus test I wanted, I said, was the assurance of a judge’s honesty and judicial integrity. As in California, I wanted judges who would interpret the Constitution, not try to rewrite it.

At a meeting with Bill Smith on June 21, after paring down a list that included several other distinguished women, I made the tentative decision to nominate Sandra Day O’Connor of the Arizona Court of Appeals to the U.S. Supreme Court.

Everything we had learned about her during our months of searching convinced me she was a woman of great legal intellect, fairness, and integrity—the antithesis of an ideological judge, and just what I wanted on the court.

On July 1, I met with her at the White House. She was forthright and convincing, and I had no doubt she was the right woman for the job. I appointed her and she turned out to be everything I hoped for.

In early May, FBI agents implicated a Libyan terrorist in a Chicago murder and we responded by ordering the Libyan